CoinDesk

SEPTEMBER 2026

The Definitive Stablecoin Landscape Series

Asia-Pacific



Commissioned by ripple

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Market Overview **4**

Asia-Pacific Stablecoin Infrastructure Landscape **6**

Regulatory Environment **10**

Recognition, Equivalence and the Access Question 12

Stablecoin Use Cases in APAC **13**

Payments and Cross-border Settlement 13

FX Risk Reduction and Consolidation of Liquidity 14

Tokenization and On-Chain Capital Markets 15

Virtual Accounts and Treasury Management 15

Crypto-Linked Consumer and Enterprise Products 16

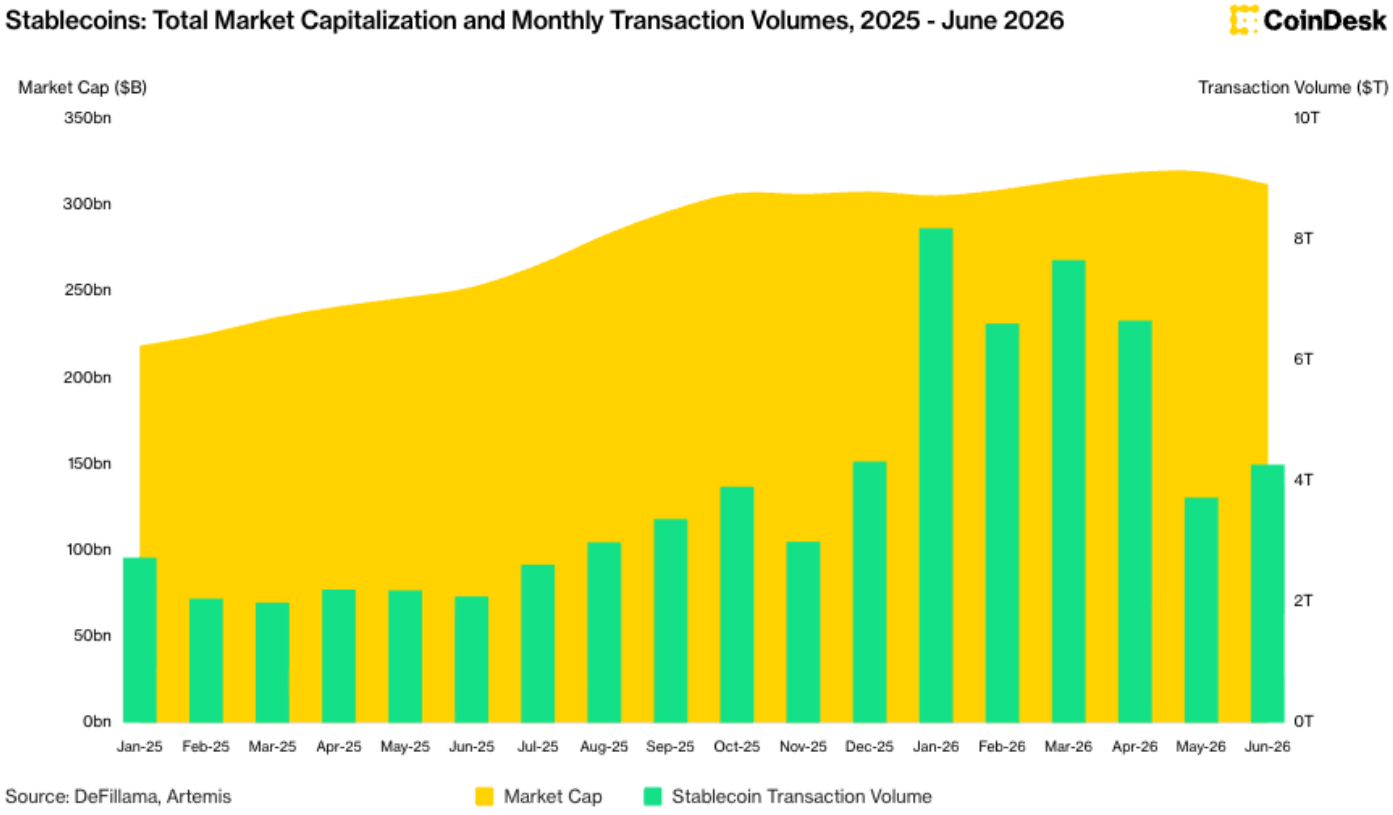
RLUSD: A Case Study Inside the APAC Stablecoin Market **17**

Strategic Outlook for Stablecoins in Asia-Pacific **21**

Conclusion **23**

Market Overview

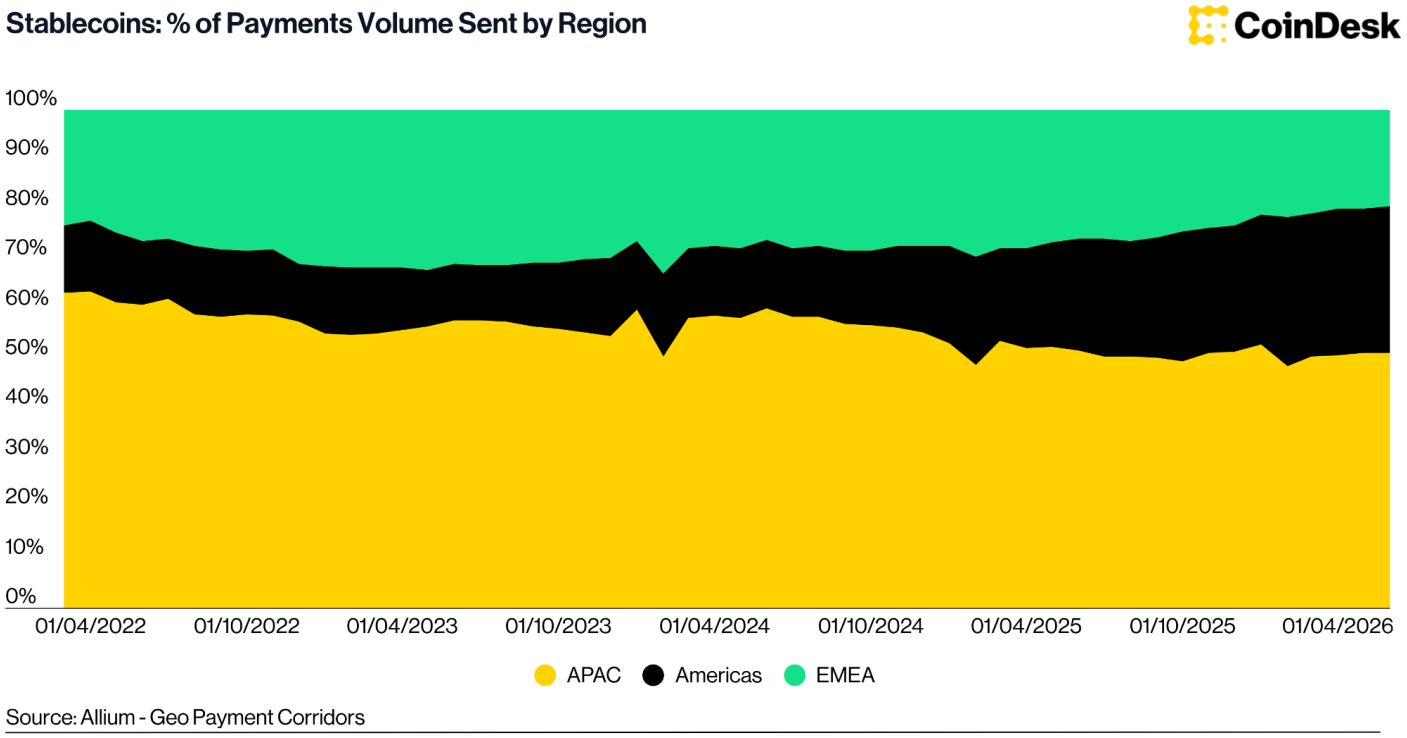
Stablecoins entered 2026 as a structural layer of global finance, with total market capitalization reaching a new all-time high of $321B in May. *In the first six months of 2026 alone, adjusted stablecoin transaction volumes reached $37.2T, already surpassing the full-year total recorded in 2025.* This highlights their growing role as a global settlement rail across exchanges, wallets, payment providers, DeFi protocols, and institutional treasury flows.



The market remains overwhelmingly dollar-denominated, with USD-backed stablecoins accounting for 99% of total market capitalization. However, usage is increasingly global, with more than 80% of stablecoin transaction volumes occurring outside North America.

Within this global landscape, Asia-Pacific has emerged as a key center of gravity for stablecoin adoption and real-world payment utility. The region *accounts for 51.2% of identified stablecoin payment volume*, making it *the largest regional hub* for stablecoin payment activity. The region's importance is supported by a combination of fragmented currency corridors, large cross-border trade flows, high fintech penetration, advanced real-time payment systems, and increasingly active regulatory hubs in Singapore, Hong Kong, Japan, and Australia.

These conditions make APAC a natural market for stablecoins to move beyond crypto-native trading and into cross-border settlement, FX access, treasury management, payrolls, and tokenized capital-market workflows. Unlike regions where adoption is driven primarily by exchange liquidity or regulatory structure alone, APAC combines deep digital-payment usage with persistent cross-border settlement frictions.



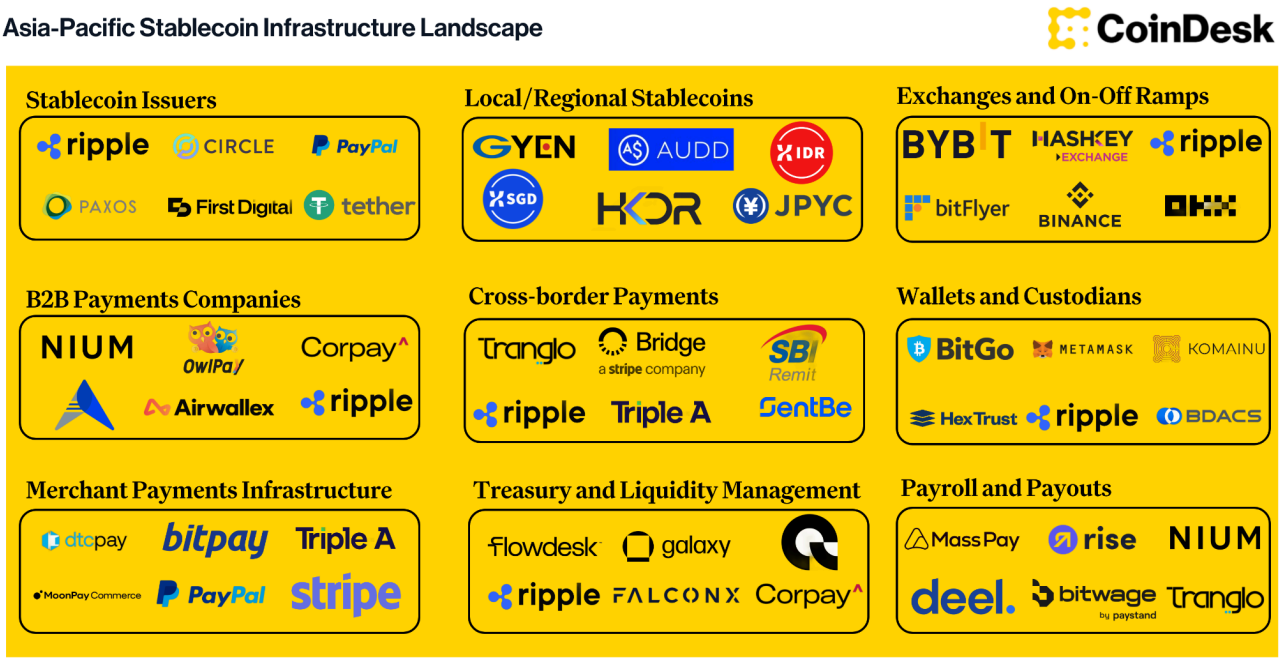
APAC's stablecoin opportunity is further strengthened by the region's broader culture of payment innovation. Across major markets, digital payments have already moved beyond cards and bank transfers into QR payments, mobile wallets, real-time payment networks, and cross-border payment linkages. India's UPI has become a global benchmark for scalable digital payments, while markets such as Singapore, Thailand, Hong Kong, Australia, and South Korea have normalized mobile-first and real-time payment experiences. Stablecoins are therefore scaling in a region where consumers, businesses, fintechs, and regulators are already familiar with digital money, instant settlement, and alternative payment rails.

Stablecoins are also developing alongside the region's wider payments ecosystem, including real-time payment systems, tokenized deposits, CBDC pilots, bank-led settlement networks, virtual-account infrastructure, and tokenized capital-market initiatives. Rather than competing with these systems directly, regulated stablecoins can form part of a broader hybrid payments architecture, extending local fiat rails into use cases requiring 24/7 settlement, cross-border reach, programmable compliance, dollar liquidity, and tokenized-asset settlement.

APAC occupies a distinct position within the global stablecoin landscape. North America has become the core market for regulated private stablecoin issuance and institutional digital-dollar infrastructure, while the U.S. policy environment has remained comparatively skeptical of retail CBDCs. Europe has taken a more regulation-led approach, with MiCA establishing a comprehensive crypto-asset framework and the digital euro project reinforcing the role of public money in digital payments. APAC sits between these models: more experimental than Europe, less centered on private stablecoins than North America, and more open to a multi-rail future in which stablecoins, tokenized deposits, CBDCs, and real-time payment systems develop side by side.

Asia-Pacific Stablecoin Infrastructure Landscape

APAC's stablecoin market is best understood as a multi-layer infrastructure stack rather than a single-token market. Issuers create and manage stablecoins, but exchanges, custodians, payment firms, treasury platforms, and capital-market infrastructure determine how they are accessed, distributed, and used in real-world workflows. This distinction matters because current usage remains largely liquidity-led, while the next phase of adoption is likely to depend increasingly on regulated market infrastructure and institutional connectivity.



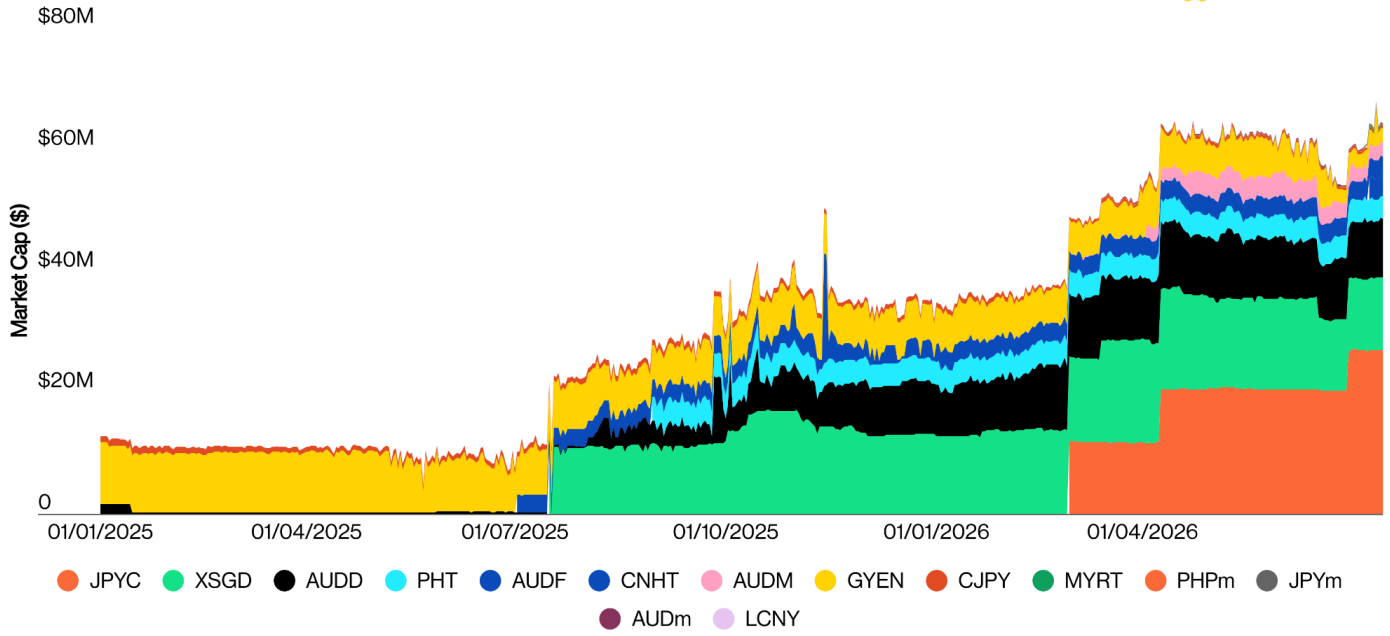
Note: The list is not exhaustive

At the issuer layer, global USD stablecoins remain central to APAC activity. USDT dominates crypto-native liquidity across many Asian markets, supported by deep exchange penetration and broad on-chain distribution. USDC, RLUSD, and Paxos-issued stablecoins represent the more compliance-focused segment of the USD stablecoin market and are better aligned with regulated institutional use cases such as payments, treasury, and tokenized-market settlement.

Regional stablecoins also illustrate how local-currency models are emerging where regulatory frameworks are clearer. StraitsX's XSGD, XUSD, and XIDR demonstrate Singapore's role as a stablecoin issuance and payments hub, while JPYC and SBI's JPYSC reflect Japan's bank-anchored approach to yen-denominated stablecoins. AUDD provides an Australian-dollar example within Australia's financial-services perimeter, while Hong Kong dollar initiatives such as HKDR reflect the market's transition from sandbox experimentation toward an active licensing regime.

Taken together, these issuers show that APAC is not a single-stablecoin market. Liquidity-led USD stablecoins continue to dominate current usage, but compliance-first and local-currency stablecoins are becoming more relevant to the region's institutional adoption story. Although non-USD stablecoins remain small in absolute terms, their market capitalization increased from $12.8M at the start of 2025 to $64.4M by July 2026, representing roughly fivefold growth. This expansion has been driven primarily by APAC-linked stablecoins denominated in JPY, AUD, SGD, PHP, and CNY, reinforcing the region's role as a testing ground for local-currency stablecoin models.

APAC Stablecoins: Market Capitalization, 2025 - Present

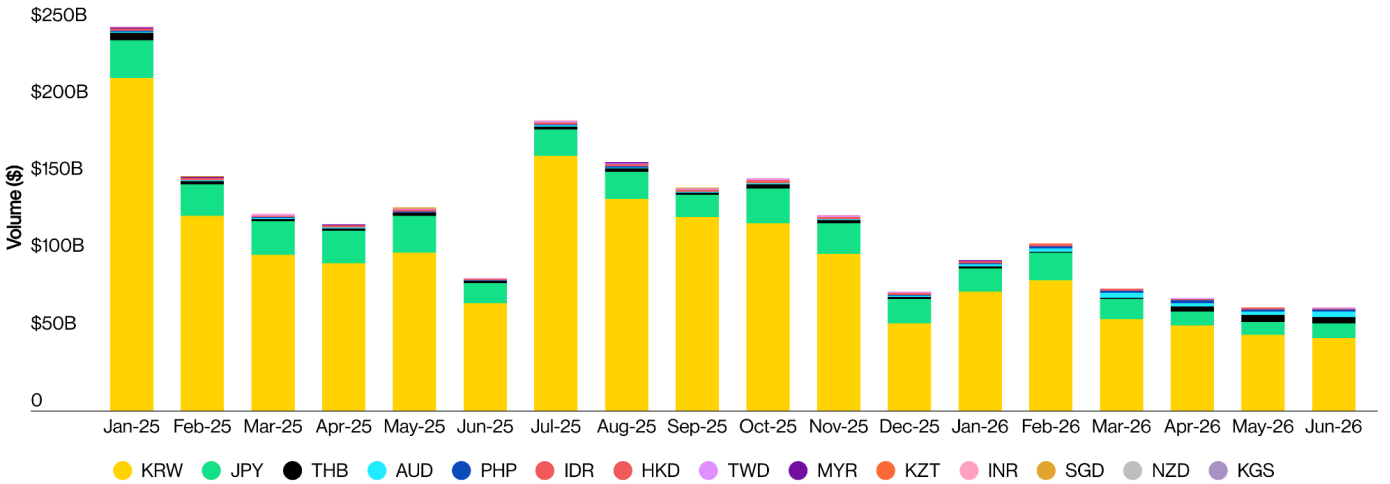


Source: DeFillama

The exchange on- and off-ramp layer helps explain why liquidity leaders have historically dominated usage. Venues such as Binance, OKX, Bybit, Bitget, Upbit, and HashKey provide trading pairs, fiat conversion, and local-market access. Stablecoins with the deepest trading pairs and broadest exchange availability often become default settlement assets for traders, market makers, and remittance users.

Across APAC, fiat access remains highly uneven and concentrated in a small number of markets. Within the CEX fiat spot dataset, KRW and JPY accounted for more than 90% of APAC fiat-denominated spot volume in H1 2026. This reinforces that stablecoin adoption will depend not only on issuance, but also on exchange access, local liquidity, and regulated on/off-ramp infrastructure.

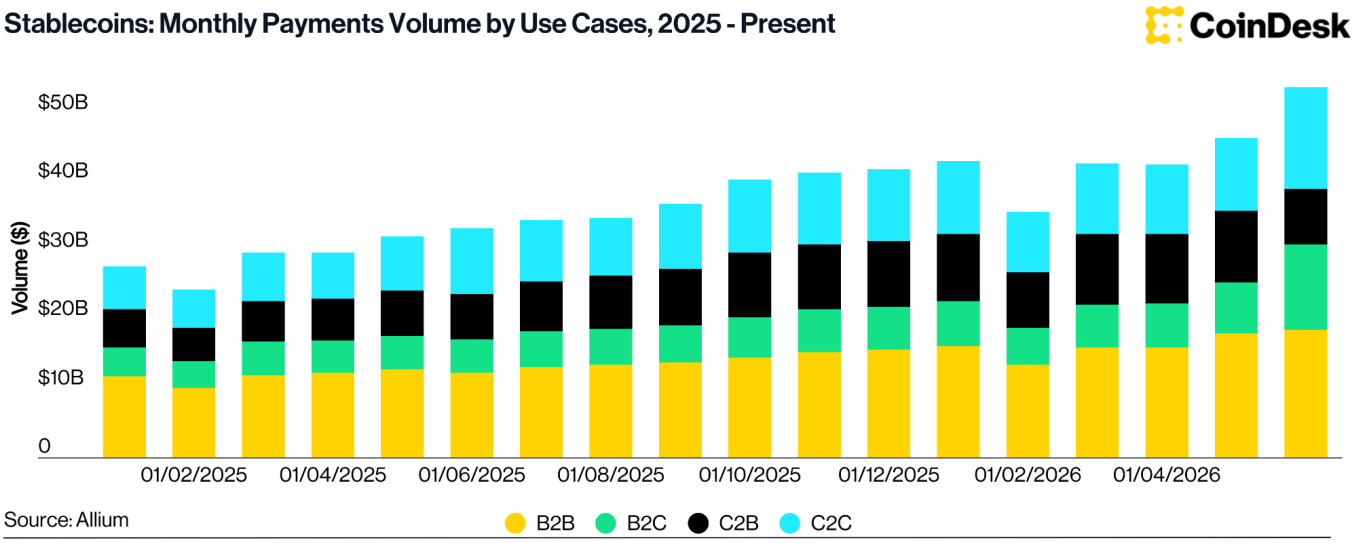
CEX Spot Trading Volumes: Fiat Volumes by APAC Currencies, 2025 - Present



Source: CoinDesk Data

The custody and wallet layer determines whether stablecoins can move from retail and crypto-native use into institutional workflows. Retail users may access stablecoins through exchange or self-custody wallets, but banks, corporates, asset managers, and payment firms require custody infrastructure that supports institutional-grade asset controls and governance. Providers such as BitGo, Hex Trust, Zodia Custody, and Komainu therefore play an important role in determining which stablecoins can be safely held and operationalized by regulated users.

Within APAC's broader infrastructure stack, the payments layer is especially important because cross-border firms such as Ripple, Nium, Bridge, Triple-A, and dtcpay connect stablecoins to the practical rails needed for payment use, including last-mile payouts, merchant acceptance, and fiat conversion. This is particularly relevant in a region where businesses often operate across fragmented currencies, multiple banking relationships, and time-zone mismatches.

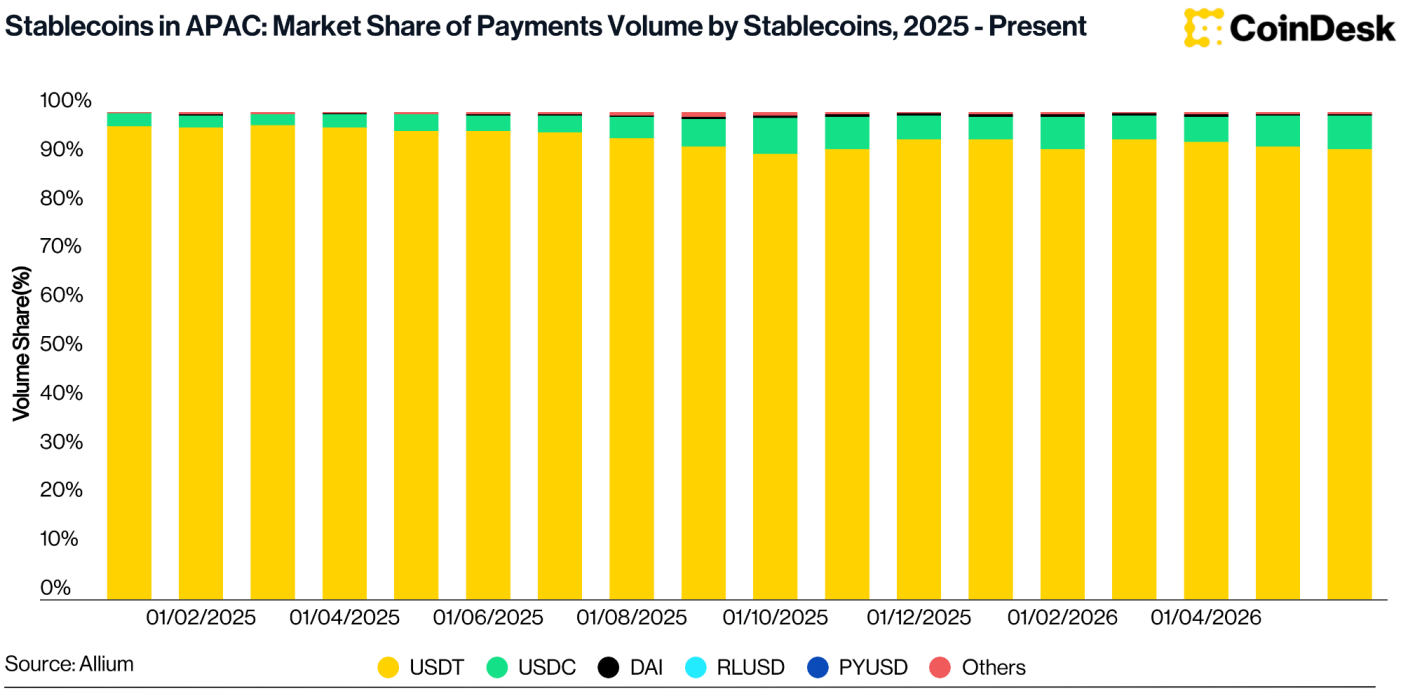


Stablecoin payment activity is already spread across business, consumer, merchant, and payout flows. Allium data shows that B2B transfers accounted for the largest share of stablecoin payment volume in H1 2026 at 37.1%, consistent with invoice settlement, supplier payments, and treasury movement. C2C flows represented 24.6%, while C2B and B2C flows accounted for 21.4% and 16.8%, respectively, highlighting merchant payments, platform collections, and business payouts. This mix suggests that stablecoin payments are developing as a broader infrastructure layer rather than solely as a consumer remittance use case.

Beyond remittances, B2B and merchant-payment infrastructure can extend stablecoin usage into enterprise payment operations. Companies such as OwlPay, Nium, Corpay, and Triple-A illustrate how stablecoins can be embedded into business and merchant-payment services, often operating behind the scenes rather than as a consumer-facing product.

Treasury and liquidity platforms extend these applications further by helping institutions manage regional cash and liquidity needs such as working capital, intercompany transfers, and FX settlement across markets. Ripple provides integrated institutional infrastructure that connects stablecoins to payments, liquidity, custody, prime brokerage, collateral, and treasury workflows, reducing the need for institutions to assemble these capabilities across separate providers. Solutions such as Ripple Payments, Ripple Prime, and Ripple Treasury illustrate how regulated stablecoins can be operationalized across enterprise financial workflows rather than functioning solely as exchange-traded tokens.

Cross-border payroll and payout infrastructure is also becoming increasingly relevant across APAC. Stablecoins can support a broad range of recurring payout use cases including salary payments and remittance-like flows, particularly in a region with large migrant-worker corridors, a global freelancer base, and high adoption of digital wallets and mobile-first financial services.



Across major Asian markets, stablecoin activity remains concentrated in incumbent USD stablecoins, particularly USDT. Its position reflects early-mover advantage, deep exchange liquidity, broad on-chain distribution, and its role as a default offshore dollar instrument across crypto-native and cross-border corridors. This first phase of adoption has been shaped primarily by network effects, exchange access, transfer costs, and liquidity availability.

However, the current liquidity map should not be mistaken for the future institutional market. As stablecoins move further into regulated financial use cases such as payments, treasury management and tokenized markets, competition is likely to expand beyond liquidity. Banks, payment firms, custodians, corporates, and regulated venues will increasingly assess institutional risk, compliance, and integration standards, including reserve transparency, licensing coverage, and AML/KYC controls. Reflecting this gradual diversification, USDT's share of identified APAC stablecoin payment volume declined from 98% at the beginning of 2025 to 91% in July 2026.

As regulation and institutional use cases develop, APAC's stablecoin market is likely to become more segmented. Liquidity-led stablecoins may continue to dominate crypto-native trading and offshore dollar flows, while compliance-first stablecoins may be better positioned for regulated institutional use. *Adoption will depend less on token availability alone and more on whether a stablecoin can be distributed, custodied, integrated, and used by regulated institutions across multiple jurisdictions.*

Regulatory Environment

Regulation is one of the most decisive forces shaping stablecoin adoption in APAC, acting as both a constraint and a catalyst. Where clear rules are absent, institutions remain cautious; where regulators establish enforceable standards for reserves, redemption, custody, distribution, and consumer protection, regulatory certainty can support broader adoption.

APAC Stablecoin Regulation: Key Markets and Regulatory Status CoinDesk

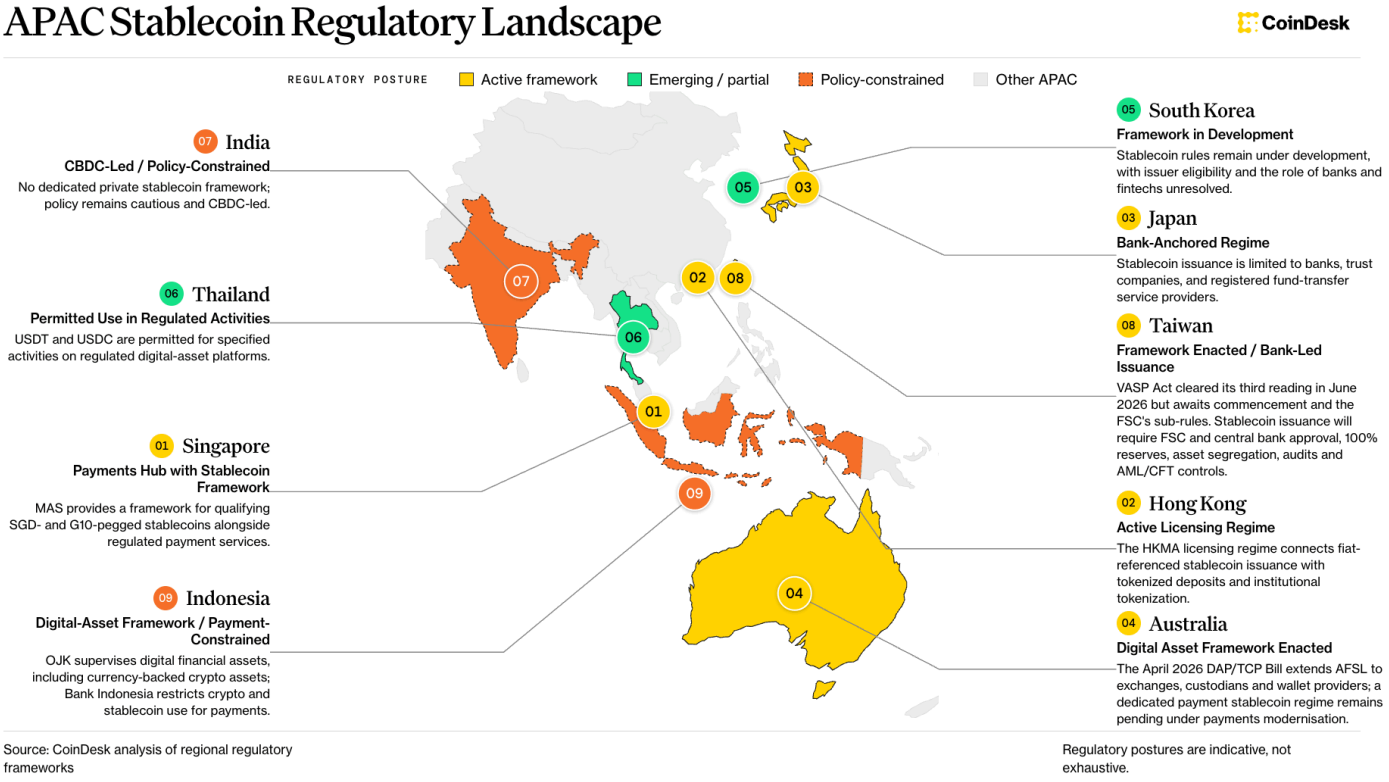
Market	Relevant framework	Regulatory posture	Main regulator(s)	Local stablecoin issuers / projects	Global stablecoins / ecosystem participants
Singapore	Payment Services Act; MAS Single-Currency Stablecoin Framework; 2026 implementation consultation	Payments hub with SCS implementation consultation and potential limited foreign-stablecoin recognition	MAS	StraitsX	Ripple / RLUSD, Paxos, Circle, XREX, Nium, Thunes, HashKey, dtcpay
Hong Kong	Stablecoins Ordinance	Active fiat-referenced stablecoin licensing regime	HKMA; SFC for exchanges/distribution	Anchorpoint Financial, HSBC; RD Technologies / HKDR and JD Coinlink as ecosystem participants	RLUSD and other offshore stablecoins treated as virtual assets where offered through permitted channels
Australia	Corporations Act / AFSL framework; ASIC digital-asset guidance; Treasury digital-asset and payments reforms	Financial-services and institutional-access perimeter	ASIC, Treasury, APRA	AUDD and licensed domestic participants	Ripple, licensed exchanges, custodians, payment firms, Project Acacia participants
Japan	Revised Payment Services Act	Bank-anchored stablecoin regime	FSA	JPYC, MUFG / Progmat, SMBC, Mizuho, DCJPY	RLUSD available through SBI VC Trade partnership
South Korea	Digital Asset Basic Act; stablecoin rules pending	Framework in progress; issuer model unresolved	FSC, BOK	KRWQ, BDACS KRW1, Naver Pay / Upbit / Dunamu GIWA, Shinhan, IBK, NongHyup, K Bank	Global stablecoin access remains subject to exchange and regulatory treatment
Thailand	Thai SEC digital-asset rules	Permitted use of selected stablecoins in regulated digital-asset activities	Thai SEC, Bank of Thailand	Programmable payment sandbox participants	USDT, USDC, licensed exchanges
India	AML/FIU framework	No dedicated stablecoin framework; CBDC-first stance	RBI, FIU-IND	No approved domestic issuer	Offshore stablecoin usage only; restrictive tax and compliance environment
Taiwan	Virtual Asset Service Act; AML Registration Regulations; Money Laundering Control Act amendments	Emerging framework; stablecoin regime enacted but implementation still developing	FSC; Central Bank of the Republic of China (Taiwan)	No live approved domestic issuer yet; initial bank-issued stablecoin model under development	Offshore stablecoins remain subject to local licensing / approval requirements and regulated VASP channels
Indonesia	OJK Regulation No. 27/2024; Draft OJK Regulation on Digital Financial Asset Offerings; P2SK	Emerging / partial; stablecoins recognized as digital financial assets, but payment use remains	OJK; Bank Indonesia	Rupiah Token; Project Garuda / national stablecoin exploration	StraitsX / XIDR and other offshore stablecoins available through regulated digital-asset channels, but

APAC's regulated stablecoin landscape is developing through several distinct models. Singapore is emerging as a regional payments and digital-asset hub, combining its payment-services licensing regime with a finalized Single-Currency Stablecoin Framework for qualifying SGD and G10-pegged stablecoins. MAS has now opened consultation on legislative amendments to implement the framework, including 100% reserve backing, restrictions on issuer-paid yield, and potential limited recognition of selected foreign-issued stablecoins under comparable overseas regimes. Its position is reinforced by MAS-led initiatives such as BLOOM (Borderless, Liquid, Open, Online, Multi-currency), which focuses on programmable settlement infrastructure for institutional use cases. BLOOM is particularly relevant to stablecoins because it explicitly considers the use of settlement assets such as tokenized commercial bank money and stablecoins that meet regulatory expectations. This makes Singapore a strong example of how regulated digital-money rails can support multi-currency settlement.

Hong Kong has moved beyond sandbox experimentation into an active licensing regime for fiat-referenced stablecoin issuers. The Stablecoins Ordinance took effect in August 2025, and the HKMA granted the first licences to Anchorpoint Financial and HSBC in April 2026. The regime is developing alongside wCBDC and tokenized-deposit initiatives, Project Ensemble, and broader capital-market tokenization efforts, positioning Hong Kong as a market where regulated stablecoins could become integrated with custody, payments, and tokenized-asset settlement.

Japan has adopted the region's most conservative, bank-anchored model, limiting stablecoin issuance to banks, trust companies, and registered fund-transfer service providers. This approach embeds stablecoins within the existing financial system and places a strong emphasis on redemption, reserve protection, and regulated intermediation.

Australia is moving from a broad financial-services perimeter toward a more defined digital-asset regime. The Corporations Amendment (Digital Assets Framework) Act 2026 introduced Digital Asset Platforms and Tokenized Custody Platforms into the Corporations Act framework and extends AFSL obligations to exchanges, custodians, and certain wallet providers. ASIC has also introduced stablecoin distribution relief, including an "exempt foreign issuer" concept for issuers supervised under comparable overseas regimes. However, a dedicated payment-stablecoin regime remains outstanding, with stablecoins expected to be addressed through stored-value facility reforms under the broader Payments System Modernization agenda.



Elsewhere, regulatory approaches remain fragmented. South Korea is still defining issuer eligibility and the structure of a domestic stablecoin regime. Thailand, meanwhile, permits selected stablecoins for specific regulated digital-asset activities rather than unrestricted payment use, including use as base trading pairs and investment in digital-token offerings. Taiwan has passed its Virtual Asset Service Act, creating a live framework for FSC and Central Bank approval of stablecoin issuance, although implementation and commercial issuance are still developing.

Indonesia has moved digital financial assets, including currency-backed crypto assets, under OJK supervision, while Bank Indonesia's rupiah legal-tender framework continues to constrain crypto and stablecoin use for payments. India, meanwhile, continues to take a cautious, CBDC-led approach, as the absence of a dedicated framework, and policymakers' continued preference for the digital rupee constrain stablecoin adoption.

The practical distinction across the region lies between issuance, distribution, and institutional use. Singapore's framework applies to qualifying SGD and G10-pegged stablecoins, while offshore stablecoins may circulate as digital payment tokens without receiving the "MAS-regulated stablecoin" label. Hong Kong requires an HKMA licence to conduct regulated fiat-referenced stablecoin issuance activities, while the distribution and marketing of unlicensed stablecoins are subject to relevant restrictions under the virtual assets regulations, particularly for retail users. Japan limits issuance to specified regulated entities, while Australia has moved toward a more defined digital-asset regime by extending AFSL obligations to digital asset platforms and tokenized custody platforms.

This fragmented regulatory map is particularly important for USD-referenced stablecoins because adoption will depend not only on where a stablecoin is issued, but also on whether it can operate within regulated financial systems across multiple jurisdictions. International standard setters have highlighted the same challenge: the Financial Stability Board's October 2025 peer review found that cross-border cooperation on crypto-asset regulation remains fragmented, inconsistent, and insufficient, with divergence in redemption, custody, disclosure, and reserve-collateralization requirements creating particular challenges for stablecoin arrangements operating across jurisdictions.

As a result, institutions are increasingly evaluating both the issuer and the broader operating environment around the stablecoin. For compliance-first stablecoins such as RLUSD, the key entry criteria will therefore extend beyond regulatory status alone. Reserve transparency, redemption reliability, custody support, institutional connectivity, and integration into financial operations will become increasingly important as APAC's stablecoin regimes mature. The most attractive markets may not simply be those with the largest retail crypto activity, but those offering the clearest route from crypto-native liquidity into regulated financial infrastructure.

Recognition, Equivalence and the Access Question

For global USD stablecoins, mutual recognition and equivalence mechanisms may become one of the most important regulatory variables shaping cross-border functionality and use by regulated institutions across APAC. Reserve quality, redemption rights, and independent attestations only support cross-border use where the host market can acknowledge comparable home-jurisdiction supervision. Without such recognition, global stablecoins risk becoming fragmented by national rules.

Three recognition models are beginning to emerge across major markets. In the United States, the GENIUS Act allows the Treasury to determine whether a foreign stablecoin regime is comparable to the federal framework, creating a pathway for stablecoins from qualifying jurisdictions to be offered in the U.S. Australia has taken a similar direction through ASIC's relief instrument, which introduces an "exempt foreign issuer" concept that defers to comparable home-jurisdiction supervision. Japan has also moved toward recognition, with the FSA's amended Cabinet Office Ordinance allowing qualifying foreign trust-type stablecoins to be treated as electronic payment instruments when handled by registered domestic intermediaries. Singapore is now consulting on a limited recognition pathway for selected foreign-issued stablecoins regulated under comparable overseas frameworks.

By contrast, Hong Kong operates a licensing regime without an equivalence pathway, meaning a stablecoin issued outside the jurisdiction cannot obtain domestic regulatory status solely on the basis of strong home-market supervision. *This makes recognition a practical access question: without implemented equivalence pathways, even well-regulated stablecoins may need market-by-market permissions before they can be used by regulated institutions across APAC.*

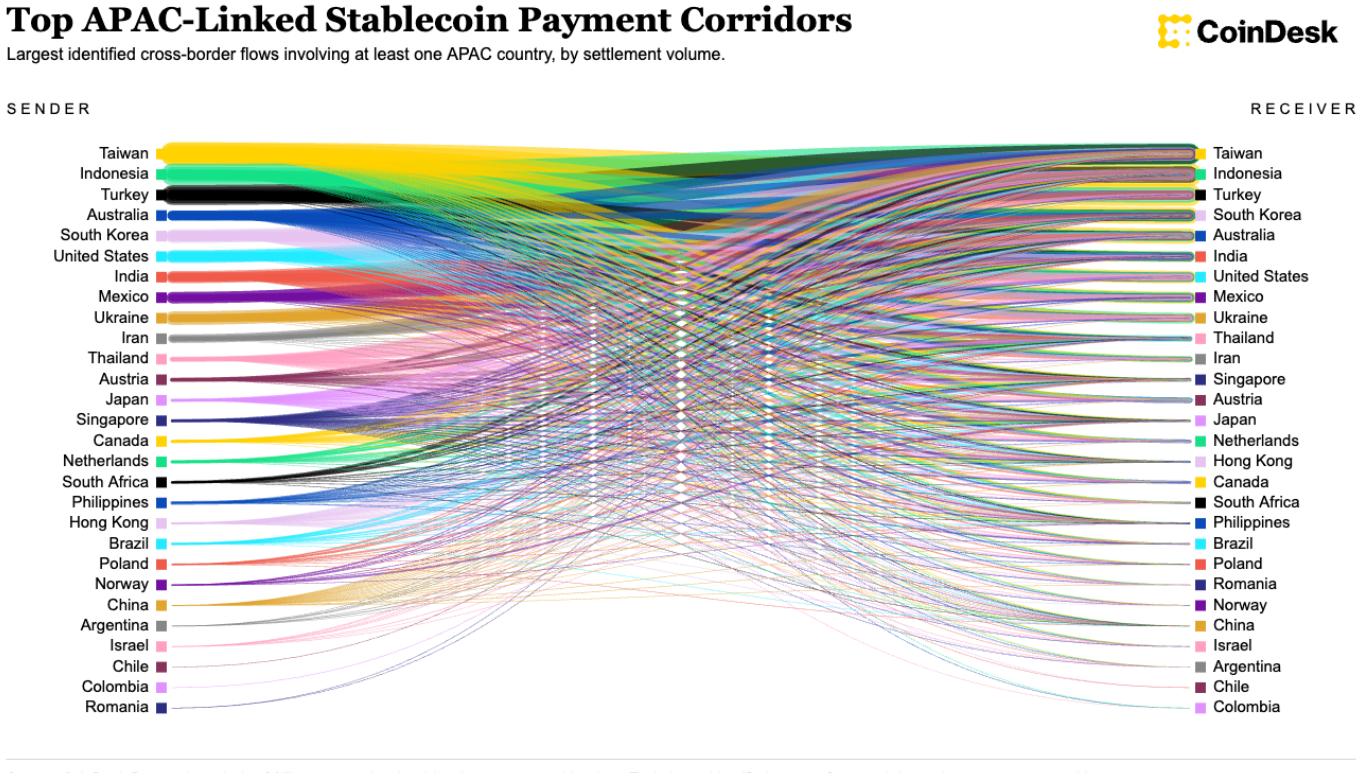
Stablecoin Use Cases in APAC

Stablecoin adoption in APAC is being shaped by practical institutional needs rather than crypto-native trading alone. The strongest use cases are emerging where the region's existing financial infrastructure continues to face cross-border friction, particularly across payments, liquidity, and capital-market functions. These use cases reflect APAC's core market structure: fragmented currencies, multi-time-zone operations, large trade corridors, active fintech ecosystems, and growing demand for regulated digital-asset infrastructure.

Payments and Cross-border Settlement

Payments and cross-border settlement remain the clearest near-term stablecoin use cases in APAC, particularly across remittance and trade corridors where fragmented currencies, restricted dollar access, and pre-funded banking arrangements continue to create friction. Although domestic payment systems in markets such as India, Singapore, Thailand, Hong Kong, and Australia have become faster and more efficient, cross-border transactions still often rely on correspondent banks, FX intermediaries, banking-hour cut-offs, and multiple compliance checks.

Stablecoins can complement existing payment systems by providing a 24/7 settlement layer while local fiat rails continue to manage the first and last mile. This is particularly valuable across trade corridors where pre-funding is costly, access to U.S. dollar liquidity is limited, or settlement speed is critical, enabling just-in-time funding, faster supplier payments, and more efficient access to harder-to-reach markets. Corpay's use of RLUSD for funding and settlement across Asia-Pacific illustrates how this model can reduce reliance on pre-funded balances and improve liquidity mobility.



Source: CoinDesk Research analysis of Allium country-level stablecoin payment corridor data. Excludes unidentified country flows and domestic same-country corridors.

Country-level corridor data reinforces APAC's role in stablecoin-enabled cross-border settlement. After filtering for corridors involving at least one APAC country, the dataset captures 426 APAC-linked payment corridors across 28 countries, representing $30.9B in stablecoin payment volume and 14.2M transactions. Activity is concentrated around Taiwan, South Korea, Indonesia, India, and Australia, with major bilateral flows including Taiwan→Indonesia, Taiwan→South Korea, and Taiwan→Australia. This suggests that stablecoin activity is developing across a broad network of intra-regional and APAC-to-global payment corridors rather than being limited to isolated remittance routes.

The presence of APAC-linked flows involving markets such as Turkey, the United States, Mexico, Ukraine, Iran, and Brazil further highlights the region's role as a bridge between Asian payment networks and broader emerging-market settlement flows. In this context, stablecoins are best understood as connective infrastructure: they do not replace domestic payment rails, but help bridge gaps between markets, currencies, and counterparties.

Corridor readiness remains the key constraint. Stablecoin settlement can improve speed, liquidity mobility, and operational efficiency, but production deployment depends on the quality of local market infrastructure and regulatory access. Adoption is therefore likely to scale fastest where strong payment demand overlaps with reliable on- and off-ramps, deep local liquidity, and trusted last-mile payout infrastructure.

FX Risk Reduction and Consolidation of Liquidity

FX risk reduction and liquidity consolidation are closely linked stablecoin use cases in APAC. Regional businesses often operate across fragmented currency and banking networks, creating pools of capital across local accounts, pre-funded balances, and correspondent banking relationships.

Stablecoins can reduce this fragmentation by providing a common settlement asset across markets. Although they do not eliminate FX risk, they can shorten settlement windows, improve access to dollar liquidity, and give firms greater control over when and where conversions occur, provided the relevant corridor has regulatory permission, compliant on/off ramps, and sufficient local fiat liquidity. This can support faster supplier payments, marketplace payouts, partner settlement, and regional treasury rebalancing.

Regulated USD stablecoins such as RLUSD and USDC illustrate how a common settlement asset could support cross-border transactions across multiple currencies and counterparties. In RLUSD's case, integration with Ripple's payments and treasury infrastructure could help institutions manage cross-border operations, particularly in corridors with fragmented local-currency liquidity or limited banking-hour coverage.

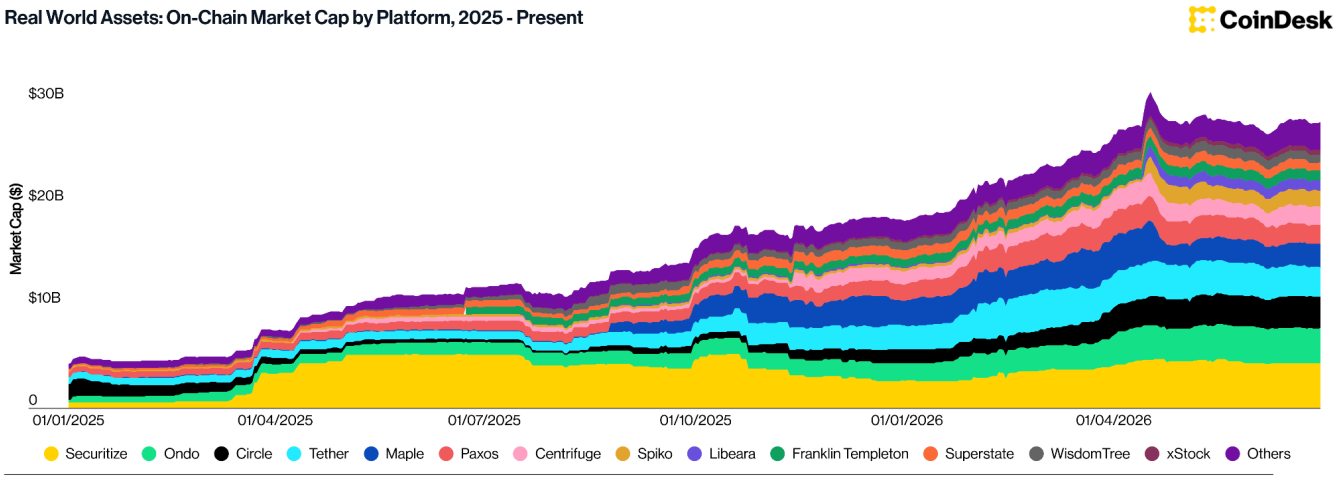
APAC corridors also appear comparatively efficient in stablecoin payment-routing data. Data from Borderless.xyz reported a median spread of 6.1 basis points across its Asia-Pacific network in Q2 2026, with markets including Australia, Japan, Singapore, South Korea, Thailand, Vietnam, Malaysia, Indonesia, and the Philippines showing relatively low delivery costs. India was the notable exception, where delivery costs were driven primarily by tax and rail-related factors rather than FX pricing. These benefits depend on integration with reliable on- and off-ramps, custody support, and compliant payout networks. Liquidity consolidation is therefore an infrastructure-led use case rather than simply a function of the stablecoin itself.

Tokenization and On-Chain Capital Markets

Tokenization and on-chain capital markets are emerging as one of the most important institutional use cases for stablecoins in APAC. As money-market funds, treasuries, and other real-world assets move on-chain, the market requires a reliable digital cash leg for settlement. Without one, tokenization improves issuance, transferability, and transparency, while leaving settlement dependent on off-chain cash movement, banking hours, reconciliation, and fragmented payment rails. The friction is relocated rather than removed, and the efficiency gain that justified tokenization is handed back at the moment of settlement.

Whether that cash leg exists is a regulatory question, not a technical one: a regulated institution can only settle against a stablecoin it is permitted to hold, and will only do so at scale if holding it does not attract a punitive capital charge. Where both conditions are met, stablecoins can help compress settlement through more efficient subscriptions and redemptions, delivery-versus-payment on trade date, and liquidity that moves outside banking hours; where either fails, the tokenized instrument settles the old way.

The growth of tokenized assets reinforces this opportunity. Total on-chain market capitalization for tokenized real-world assets reached $27.9B at the end of Q2 2026, up 52.3% year-to-date and 137% year-on-year. Although below the April 2026 peak of $30.9B, the market remains near record highs, underscoring that tokenization is moving from experimentation toward institutional market structure.



This is most visible in Singapore and Hong Kong, where tokenized funds, deposits, wholesale CBDC experiments, and institutional tokenization initiatives are developing in parallel. DBS, Franklin Templeton, and Ripple, for example, are partnering in Singapore to support trading and lending solutions involving Franklin Templeton's tokenized money-market fund and RLUSD, while MAS plans to issue tokenized MAS bills to primary dealers, settled in wholesale CBDC. In Hong Kong, Project Ensemble has moved into its EnsembleTX phase, testing real-value transactions across tokenized deposits and digital assets. In these workflows, stablecoins can become programmable settlement assets for tokenized securities, repo-style transactions, and on-chain liquidity management.

Virtual Accounts and Treasury Management

Virtual accounts and treasury management are a natural extension of stablecoin adoption in APAC. Corporates, trading firms, and payment companies often need to manage collections, payouts, intercompany transfers, and working capital across multiple markets, creating friction when funds are spread across different currencies, banking partners, local accounts, and jurisdictions.

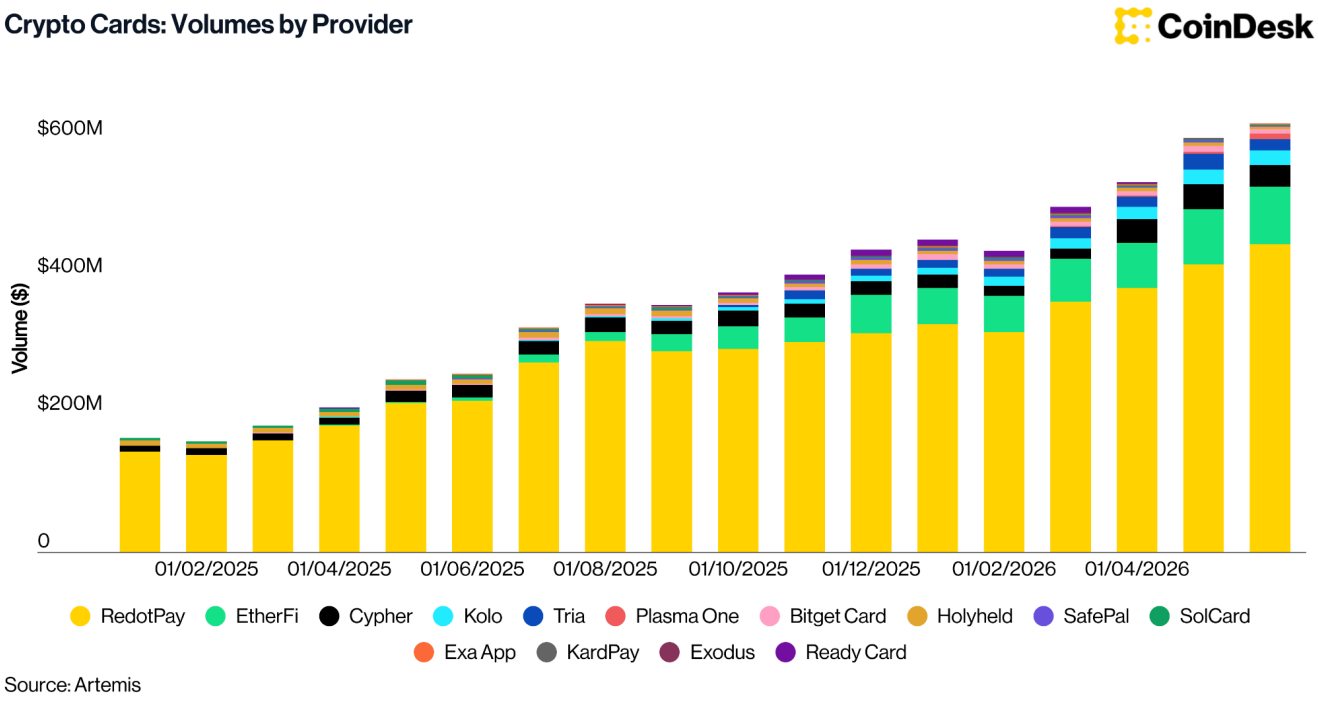
Stablecoins can support more dynamic treasury operations by acting as a 24/7 settlement rail between operating accounts, subsidiaries, counterparties, and payment partners. When combined with virtual accounts, custody infrastructure, and treasury-management systems, they can help firms automate collections, sweep balances, reduce idle liquidity, and improve reconciliation across markets.

These applications are especially relevant where firms need to move liquidity outside banking hours or across corridors where settlement remains slow. Stablecoins are not replacing treasury systems or banking relationships; they are becoming an additional settlement layer that can improve liquidity mobility and operational efficiency.

Crypto-Linked Consumer and Enterprise Products

Crypto-linked consumer and enterprise products are becoming an important stablecoin use case in APAC, supported by the region's high adoption of mobile wallets, QR payments, super apps, and platform-based financial services. Stablecoins can be embedded into wallets, cards, merchant tools, and enterprise-payment products, allowing users and businesses to access digital-dollar settlement without directly managing blockchain infrastructure.

Stablecoin-linked card activity further reflects this shift. Transaction volume across major crypto-linked card providers reached $3.16B in H1 2026, with monthly volume rising to a record $624M in June. This growth points to increasing stablecoin use across both consumer and business-payment products.



Source: Artemis

For consumers, stablecoins can support wallet balances, crypto-linked cards, peer-to-peer transfers, and cross-border spending. For enterprises, they can support platform and merchant-payment operations, including merchant payouts, supplier payments, and embedded-finance products. In most cases, the stablecoin will operate in the background while users interact with familiar apps, cards, wallets, or merchant interfaces. Adoption will therefore depend on regulated platforms and service providers that can manage the operating layer behind the user experience, such as payment providers and custodians.

RLUSD: A Case Study Inside the APAC Stablecoin Market

RLUSD provides a useful case study for the type of stablecoin model that may become more relevant as APAC adoption moves beyond crypto-native liquidity and toward regulated payments, treasury management, and tokenized capital-market workflows. While the region's stablecoin market remains largely liquidity-led, institutional adoption is likely to depend increasingly on integration with regulated financial infrastructure and the features that matter to financial institutions such as regulatory compliance, reserve quality, redemption reliability, enterprise-grade security and custody.

Issued by Standard Custody & Trust Company, a NYDFS-chartered limited-purpose trust company, RLUSD is designed as a compliance-first U.S. dollar stablecoin. It is fully backed by segregated reserve assets comprising cash and short-dated U.S. treasuries, designed to be redeemable 1:1 for U.S. dollars, and supported by monthly independent attestations and institutional-grade controls. Ripple also received preliminary conditional approval from the OCC in December 2025 to establish Ripple National Trust Bank, creating a pathway toward both state-level NYDFS supervision and federal OCC oversight. This dual-supervision pathway strengthens RLUSD's institutional positioning as regulators across Singapore, Hong Kong, Japan, and Australia place greater emphasis on stablecoin risk controls and permitted use.

RLUSD remains at an earlier stage of APAC distribution than incumbent stablecoins, but its relevance lies in the model it represents: a regulated digital dollar designed for institutional settlement rather than primarily for exchange-based liquidity. The current APAC liquidity map should not be mistaken for the future institutional market, where adoption is likely to depend not only on liquidity, but also on compliance and licensing features that enable it to be seamlessly integrated into regulated institutional workflows such as tokenized-market settlement.

Institutional requirement	RLUSD / Ripple positioning
Regulatory clarity	RLUSD is issued by Standard Custody & Trust Company, a NYDFS-chartered limited-purpose trust company.
Multi-jurisdictional licensing	Ripple holds more than 75 licences globally, including a Major Payment Institution licence in Singapore. Its proposed acquisition of BC Payments Australia could provide a pathway to expand its regulated payments capabilities in Australia, subject to completion.
Reserve quality and redemption confidence	RLUSD is fully backed by highly liquid reserve assets, including cash, short-dated U.S. Treasuries, and other permitted cash equivalents. BNY Mellon provides primary reserve custody, while Deloitte performs monthly independent attestations.
Custody and operational controls	Ripple Custody, supported by Metaco and Palisade, provides institutional custody and wallet infrastructure that could support RLUSD and broader digital-asset operations.
Regional operating history	Ripple has maintained its APAC headquarters in Singapore since 2017 and has operated through its SBI joint venture since 2016.
Enterprise connectivity and operational integration	Ripple connects RLUSD to enterprise payment, treasury, liquidity, custody, and settlement workflows, helping institutions operationalize stablecoins through existing financial processes rather than building standalone crypto infrastructure.
End-to-end infrastructure	Ripple Payments connects fiat and stablecoin settlement, Ripple Prime adds liquidity and collateral infrastructure, and Ripple Treasury extends into corporate treasury management. Rail and Palisade strengthen payment orchestration and wallet infrastructure.

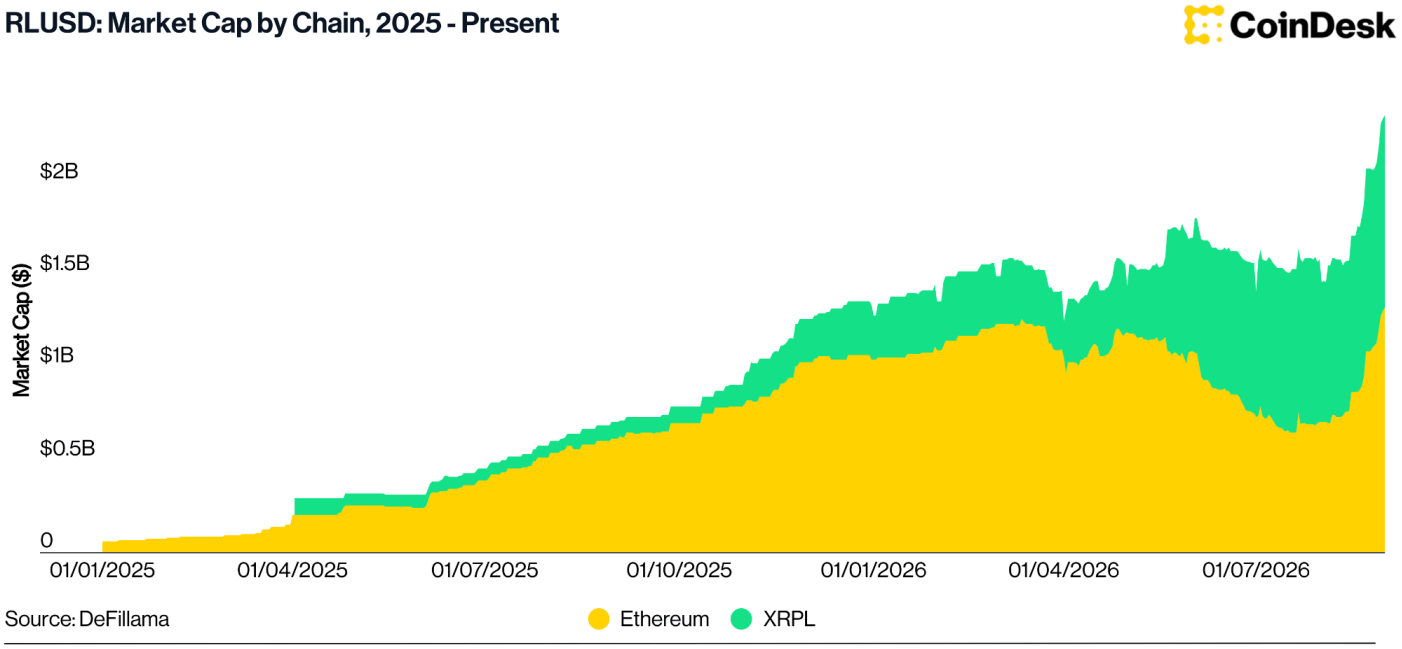
APAC adoption will depend not only on where a stablecoin is issued, but also on where it can be used by regulated institutions. Ripple's licensing footprint gives RLUSD a stronger foundation in this respect. In Singapore, Ripple holds a Major Payment Institution licence from MAS, providing a regulated base for cross-border payment activity in one of APAC's most important digital-asset hubs. In Australia, Ripple's acquisition of BC Payments Australia, now Ripple Payments Australia, strengthened its regulated payments footprint and could support a future RLUSD payments presence in the market, subject to local regulatory permissions.

For institutional users, RLUSD's appeal also depends on whether its reserve structure, custody model, and operational controls can meet bank-grade risk requirements. Its reserves are held within a regulated framework and supported by monthly independent attestations, with BNY Mellon providing primary reserve custody and Ripple Custody supporting institutional digital-asset operations.

Banks, payment firms, asset managers, and corporations are unlikely to adopt stablecoins at scale unless they can meet internal requirements around counterparty risk, reserves, compliance, custody, redemption, reporting, and operational governance. For many institutions, adoption may depend less on rebuilding their own architecture and more on working with licensed partners that already provide the institutional operating layer around the stablecoin, making the surrounding regulatory and operating framework as important as the token itself.

RLUSD also enters APAC with the benefit of Ripple's established regional presence rather than as a standalone stablecoin seeking to build distribution from scratch. Ripple has maintained its APAC headquarters in Singapore since 2017, operated through SBI Ripple Asia since 2016, and developed relationships spanning cross-border payments, remittances, custody, and tokenization. This operating history provides a foundation of regulatory experience, institutional relationships, and regional infrastructure that could support future RLUSD adoption across selected APAC markets.

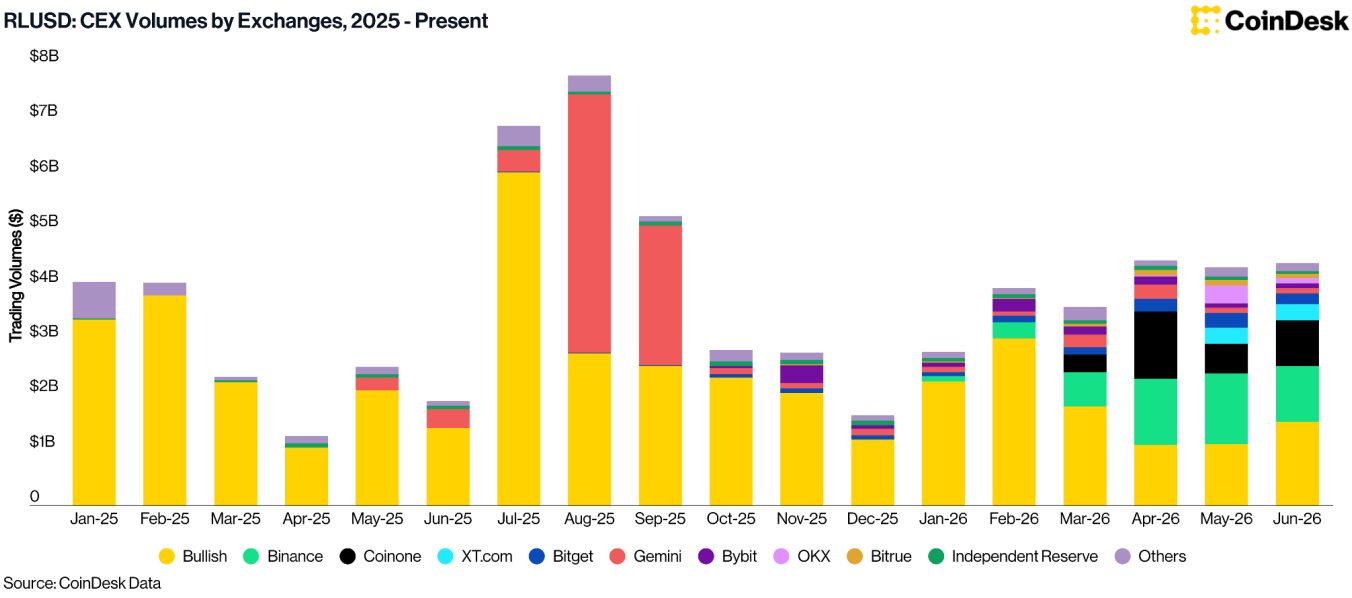
RLUSD's relevance to APAC's institutional use cases is further strengthened by its position within Ripple's broader financial infrastructure stack. Ripple Payments connects fiat and stablecoin settlement across global corridors and supports payment orchestration; Ripple Prime adds prime brokerage, clearing, financing, liquidity, and collateral infrastructure; Ripple Treasury extends the offering into corporate cash and liquidity management; and Ripple Custody strengthens wallet and custody capabilities. For institutions operating across fragmented currencies, multiple banking relationships, pre-funded balances, and time-zone mismatches, this infrastructure creates potential routes for RLUSD into institutional financial operations such as payments, treasury, and payout workflows.



RLUSD's early growth has also been accompanied by a more balanced multi-chain distribution. As of September 2026, RLUSD market capitalization stood at $2.37B. During June, supply on XRPL overtook Ethereum for the first time, with XRPL accounting for 52.0% of outstanding supply and Ethereum accounting for 48.0%, showing that more RLUSD liquidity is moving onto Ripple's native settlement infrastructure while still maintaining access to Ethereum's wider DeFi, exchange, custody, and tokenized-asset ecosystem. Beyond XRPL and Ethereum, Ripple has expanded RLUSD's native availability across additional high-activity blockchain environments, including Base, Optimism, Ink, Unichain, and the XRPL EVM Sidechain. This gives RLUSD a broader distribution path across Ripple's own settlement infrastructure, Ethereum, Ethereum L2 ecosystems, and XRPL-compatible smart-contract environments, strengthening its utility for payments, liquidity movement, and tokenized-market settlement.

Beyond RLUSD itself, XRPL gives Ripple a broader role in APAC's stablecoin infrastructure by supporting both U.S. dollar and local-currency stablecoins. Fiat-backed stablecoins available on XRPL include, but are not limited to, USDC, RLUSD, Novatti AUDD, Braza Bank BBRL, Societe Generale's EURCV, and StraitsX's XSGD, creating the foundations of a potential multi-currency settlement layer that combines regulated U.S. dollar stablecoins with APAC-linked local-currency infrastructure. APAC's future stablecoin market is unlikely to be defined by a single token or currency. It is more likely to involve U.S. dollar stablecoins, local-currency stablecoins, tokenized deposits, CBDCs, and bank-led settlement rails operating alongside one another.

RLUSD's exchange footprint has also expanded across the largest global exchanges, including Binance, OKX, and Bybit, improving its access to liquidity, trading pairs, and user base. APAC-facing listings such as Upbit, Bithumb, Coinone, Korbit, Bitkub, OSL, HashKey, Independent Reserve, and Mobee extend its regional distribution across the APAC landscape. Centralized exchange activity is not the core institutional use case for RLUSD, but listings remain important because stablecoins require market access and liquidity formation to support payments, treasury management, and settlement.



RLUSD's strategic fit is further supported by Ripple's broader APAC infrastructure footprint. Across the region, Ripple has developed relationships spanning APAC's payments, custody, and tokenization ecosystem. These relationships should not be interpreted as evidence that every partner currently supports or uses RLUSD, as many predate the stablecoin and were established around Ripple Payments, custody, liquidity, or blockchain infrastructure.

These relationships create potential channels for future RLUSD distribution and integration, subject to partner adoption, commercial demand, technical implementation, and local regulatory requirements.

Selected Ripple APAC Relationships and Potential RLUSD Use Cases CoinDesk

Use case	Selected Ripple relationships in APAC	Potential relevance for RLUSD
Cross-border payments and remittances	Tranglo, Nium, Siam Commercial Bank, SBI Remit	Existing payment corridors and payout networks could support future RLUSD settlement, subject to partner adoption, technical integration, and local regulation.
B2B and SME payments	MoneyMatch, AltPayNet, ECIB	Existing enterprise-payment relationships could provide future channels for RLUSD-based collections, supplier payments, and cross-border settlement.
Treasury, liquidity, and payouts	Corpay, Instarem, Nium, MassPay	Treasury and payment integrations could support RLUSD for funding, liquidity movement, payouts, and reduced pre-funding. Corpay is a publicly confirmed example of RLUSD use in APAC.
Custody and tokenization	BDACS, Securitize, SBI Group	Custody and tokenization infrastructure could support RLUSD as a settlement asset, collateral instrument, or digital cash leg for tokenized products.
Regional corridor connectivity	SentBe, Novatti, SBI Remit	Existing payment connectivity could provide future routes for RLUSD distribution, conversion, and settlement across selected APAC corridors.

Note: The relationships shown reflect Ripple's broader APAC payments, treasury, custody, liquidity, and tokenization footprint. Inclusion does not indicate that every organization currently supports or uses RLUSD.

This regional footprint matters because institutional stablecoin adoption depends on more than token availability. Payment firms and financial institutions also require local operating infrastructure, including fiat conversion, payout coverage, and compliance workflows. Ripple's existing APAC integrations could therefore provide RLUSD with a clearer route into payment, treasury, and settlement workflows, particularly in corridors affected by pre-funding requirements, banking-hour constraints, limited dollar access, and fragmented liquidity. Corpay already uses RLUSD for cross-border funding and settlement in APAC, while RLUSD's integration with Securitize positions it as a potential settlement asset for tokenized financial products. BDACS' use of Ripple Custody in South Korea also demonstrates the institutional infrastructure that could support future stablecoin and tokenized-asset activity.

RLUSD's potential fit across these workflows depends on the broader infrastructure surrounding it. Cross-border payments require fiat liquidity, payout coverage, compliance controls, and last-mile connectivity, while treasury and tokenized-market workflows depend on custody, reporting, collateral mobility, and regulated counterparties.

Ripple connects RLUSD to these capabilities through Ripple Payments, Ripple Prime, Ripple Custody, and Ripple Treasury, creating multiple potential routes into real-world financial activity. These capabilities do not yet represent widespread RLUSD adoption across APAC, but they provide an infrastructure base through which usage could develop as institutions evaluate regulated stablecoin applications.

Liquidity-led stablecoins are likely to remain dominant in crypto-native markets, while compliance-first stablecoins such as RLUSD may be better suited to regulated institutional use. The key test will be whether Ripple can convert its APAC infrastructure into recurring institutional stablecoin activity.

Strategic Outlook for Stablecoins in Asia-Pacific

Over the next two to three quarters, stablecoin adoption in Asia-Pacific is likely to be shaped by regulatory implementation, the expansion of tokenized capital markets, and the development of commercially viable cross-border settlement corridors. The region has already established itself as a major center of stablecoin activity, but the next phase of growth will depend less on aggregate transaction volumes and more on whether stablecoins become embedded in regulated financial infrastructure.

Singapore and Hong Kong are likely to remain the most important near-term markets because both combine increasingly clear stablecoin regulation with broader institutional payments and tokenization infrastructure. Singapore brings together a framework for qualifying SGD- and G10-pegged stablecoins, an established payment-services regime, and a growing institutional tokenization ecosystem. Hong Kong has moved into an active licensing phase, with its stablecoin regime developing alongside tokenized deposits, Project Ensemble, and broader capital-market tokenization initiatives.

Elsewhere, adoption is likely to follow different paths across the region. Japan's bank-anchored model may support slower but more institutionally integrated growth, while Australia provides a route through its existing financial-services perimeter. South Korea remains important as policymakers define issuer eligibility and the structure of a domestic stablecoin regime, Thailand has adopted a more usage-led approach, and India is likely to remain constrained by its cautious stance toward private stablecoins and continued focus on the digital rupee.

As banks, asset managers, exchanges, and custodians across APAC expand tokenized funds, deposits, bonds, and other real-world assets, demand for a reliable digital cash leg is likely to grow. Stablecoins could support the settlement layer for tokenized-market activity, while coexisting with tokenized deposits, wholesale CBDCs, and bank-led settlement networks.

APAC's fragmented currencies, large trade corridors, uneven dollar access, and reliance on pre-funded accounts also create a strong case for faster settlement and more efficient liquidity movement. Adoption will remain corridor-specific and depend on local market readiness, including fiat liquidity, trusted payout partners, and reliable transaction monitoring. The strongest opportunities are therefore likely to emerge where high payment demand overlaps with regulatory clarity and mature financial infrastructure.

As different stablecoins become aligned with distinct use cases, APAC's regional market is likely to become increasingly segmented. USDT may retain its dominant position in crypto-native trading and offshore dollar liquidity, while compliance-first stablecoins such as USDC and RLUSD may be better positioned for institutional financial use cases. Local-currency stablecoins may also gain relevance in selected domestic and regional workflows, particularly where they are supported by banks, licensed payment firms, or established financial institutions.

For RLUSD, the key indicators will be distribution, liquidity, and confirmed institutional use across Ripple's broader infrastructure. Its exchange footprint and multi-chain supply provide a base level of market access, but the more important test is whether RLUSD becomes embedded in recurring institutional activity such as payments, treasury, and tokenized-asset workflows.

Ripple's existing APAC relationships could provide channels for this expansion, although they should not be treated as evidence of current RLUSD adoption unless usage has been publicly confirmed. Ripple has also expanded the infrastructure around RLUSD through acquisitions and product integrations. Ripple Prime adds liquidity, financing, clearing, and collateral capabilities; Ripple Treasury extends the offering into corporate treasury management; Ripple Payments supports stablecoin payment orchestration; and Ripple Custody adds institutional custody and wallet infrastructure.

Although Ripple has assembled this broader infrastructure, it will not guarantee RLUSD adoption. Success will depend on whether these capabilities translate into confirmed institutional usage and recurring real-world flows.

Ripple Solution	Pillar	Description
Ripple Prime	Prime brokerage	Provides institutional prime brokerage infrastructure, building on Ripple's acquisition of Hidden Road to support liquidity access, financing, and collateralized trading across traditional and digital assets.
Ripple Treasury	Treasury management	Provides treasury-management infrastructure for enterprises managing cash, liquidity, and payments across traditional and digital-asset workflows, building on GTreasury, now Ripple Treasury.
Ripple Payments	End-to-end payments infrastructure	Connects fiat and stablecoin rails so institutions can launch and scale global payment, settlement, collection, and payout workflows without building infrastructure from scratch
Ripple Custody	Institutional Custody	Provides institutional-grade custody and orchestration infrastructure for safeguarding, managing, transferring, and settling digital assets.

Fragmentation remains the principal risk to the regional outlook, as stablecoin issuers and infrastructure providers must navigate differing rules on issuance, distribution, custody, redemption, and retail access across jurisdictions. However, this divergence may narrow over time as recognition mechanisms in the U.S., Australia, and Japan create pathways for qualifying foreign stablecoins to access host markets based on comparable home-jurisdiction supervision. Incumbent stablecoins will continue to benefit from strong network effects and deep liquidity, but newer entrants could gain ground where they combine institutional credibility with stronger market integration and transaction economics.

The outlook for APAC stablecoins is therefore constructive, but increasingly selective. Crypto-native liquidity will remain an important source of demand, while regulated payments, institutional treasury, and tokenized capital markets are likely to become more significant drivers of adoption. The strongest models will combine credible issuance and reserve structures with the operating infrastructure needed for institutional scale, reinforcing APAC's role as a key testing ground for stablecoins' evolution from exchange-based instruments into regulated settlement and financial infrastructure.

Conclusion

Accounting for more than half of identified stablecoin payment volume, Asia-Pacific has established itself as a key market for the next phase of stablecoin adoption. Its combination of fragmented currency markets, large trade and remittance corridors, advanced digital-payment infrastructure, and persistent cross-border settlement frictions creates a strong foundation for stablecoins to move beyond crypto-native liquidity and into regulated payments, treasury management, and tokenized capital markets.

Rather than converging around a single regional model, APAC is developing through a range of jurisdiction-specific approaches. Singapore is combining payment-services regulation with a framework for qualifying SGD- and G10-pegged stablecoins, Hong Kong has moved into an active licensing phase alongside tokenized-deposit and capital-market initiatives, Japan has adopted a bank-anchored regime, and Australia is bringing stablecoin activity within its broader financial-services perimeter. South Korea, Thailand, and India remain at different stages of policy development, reinforcing that stablecoins will need to operate across a fragmented regulatory and financial landscape.

While regulatory fragmentation creates complexity, it also reflects the diversity of APAC's financial systems and use cases. Stablecoins are likely to coexist with tokenized deposits, CBDCs, real-time payment networks, and bank-led settlement rails rather than replace them outright. In the near term, their most realistic institutional role is as an always-on settlement and redundancy layer that can be activated when traditional infrastructure is unavailable, too slow, or too capital-intensive, particularly outside banking hours, in pre-funded corridors, and where access to dollar liquidity remains constrained.

Liquidity-led stablecoins such as USDT are likely to remain dominant in crypto-native trading and offshore dollar flows, although USDT's share of identified APAC stablecoin payment volume has declined from 98% at the beginning of 2025 to 91% in July 2026. This gradual diversification reinforces the view that as stablecoins move further into regulated financial infrastructure, competition will depend increasingly on institutional trust and usability, rather than liquidity alone.

Within this transition, RLUSD provides a useful example of the compliance-first model that may become more relevant to institutional users. Its regulated issuance, reserve structure, multi-chain availability, and growing market access provide the foundation, while Ripple's broader payments, custody, liquidity, and treasury infrastructure creates potential routes into real-world use. The key measure of success will not simply be exchange listings or circulating supply, but whether RLUSD becomes embedded in recurring institutional stablecoin activity across APAC such as cross-border settlement, treasury funding, and tokenized-asset workflows.

Taken together, the regional outlook is constructive but increasingly selective. APAC adoption will depend on far more than stablecoin issuance alone; the long-term differentiator will be the operating infrastructure that connects stablecoins to institutional finance. The strongest models will be those embedded into the workflows institutions already use to move, safeguard, convert, and settle value across markets. As banks, payment firms, corporates, and asset managers integrate stablecoins into high-friction corridors and capital-market workflows, APAC is likely to remain one of the most important proving grounds for stablecoins' evolution into global financial infrastructure.

Disclaimer

This report was commissioned by Ripple Labs, Inc. All content was produced independently by CoinDesk Research staff and does not necessarily reflect the opinions of CoinDesk, Inc. or its affiliates (collectively, "CoinDesk") or the organization that requested the report. The commissioning organization may have input on the content of the report, but CoinDesk maintains control over the final report. Author(s) may hold cryptocurrencies named in this report. This report is meant for informational purposes only. It is not meant to serve as investment advice. You should conduct your own research and consult an independent financial, tax, or legal advisor before making any investment decisions. Past performance of any asset is not indicative of future results. Changes in circumstances or underlying facts may have changed since the report was first written which may render parts of the report no longer accurate or outdated. The authors of the report are under no obligation to update the report should circumstances change. CoinDesk expressly disclaims, to the maximum extent permitted by law, all liabilities (however caused, including negligence) from any loss, claim, damages, costs or expenses of whatever nature (whether direct, indirect or consequential) including any liability arising from fault or negligence on the part of CoinDesk, any employee or officer of CoinDesk, or any other person, for any loss arising from the use of, or reliance on, the report or its contents or otherwise arising in connection with the report or any inaccuracies or omissions contained within. No part of this report may be (i) copied, photocopied or duplicated in any form by any means or (ii) redistributed without the prior written consent of CoinDesk.

The research set out in this report is based on information obtained from sources believed to be reliable, but CoinDesk has not necessarily conducted due diligence on any of the companies, verified any information or sources or taken into account any other factors which might be relevant or appropriate in preparing the research. Accordingly, we do not make any representation or warranty as to the accuracy, completeness or correctness of the research set out in this report. The valuations, opinions, estimates, forecasts, ratings or risk assessments described in this report were based upon a number of estimates and assumptions and are inherently subject to significant uncertainties and contingencies. It can be expected that one or more of the estimates on which the valuations, opinions, estimates, forecasts, ratings or risk assessments were based will not materialize or will vary significantly from actual results. Therefore, the inclusion of the valuations, opinions, estimates, forecasts, ratings or risk assessments described herein is not to be relied on as a representation and/or warranty by CoinDesk (and/or any persons associated with CoinDesk), that: (a) such valuations, opinions, estimates, forecasts, ratings or risk assessments or their underlying assumptions will be achieved; and (b) there is any assurance that future results or events will be consistent with any such valuations, opinions, estimates, forecasts, ratings or risk assessments stated therein.